

IDEAS

NATIONAL SOCIALISM

Much of the “national” element of the ideology behind Hitler’s National Socialist German Workers’ Party (the Nazi Party) appealed to the masses because it was in line with a long tradition of German nationalism. For example, belief in the creation of a self-sufficient “Greater Germany” incorporating all ethnic Germans within its borders. The term “socialism” was associated with ethnic exclusivity rather than equality. Hitler strongly opposed Marxist socialism and purged from the party all those who wanted socialism in the sense of workers’ power or the overthrow of capitalism. The core of National Socialism was not class war, but race war. Hitler intended to create a military state along racial lines. While the supposed evil power of the Jews would be crushed and “inferior” races such as the Slavs would be used as slave labor, the privileged German “Volk” would unite in solidarity behind the heroic leadership of their Führer.



“Who says I am not under the special protection of God?”

ADOLF HITLER, MARCH 23, 1933

Hitler off duty

Hitler relaxes with Eva Braun, the woman who was his companion from 1932. Hitler married her in his Berlin bunker on April 29, 1945; they both committed suicide the following day.



was the victim of an international Jewish conspiracy. It was while mixing in political extremist circles in Munich that Hitler chanced upon an exceptional talent.

When he addressed political meetings in beerhalls, his speeches stirred the crowd in a way no other agitator could achieve. His hypnotic ability to dominate and sway his listeners’ emotions gave him the first intoxicating experience of power. By the mid-1920s, through the failed Munich Putsch, a coup in which Hitler tried to overthrow the government; his subsequent nationally publicized trial; and the publication of *Mein Kampf*; Hitler had reinvented himself as the messianic leader of a German national revival. His image was manufactured and dramatized by the Nazi Party propagandists, but it depended on a steely self-belief.

Rise to power

Hitler was an opportunist who exploited a democratic system he despised to obtain absolute power, never wavering from his long-term goals—establishing a dictatorship; overturning the Versailles peace treaty that had marked the end of World War I; defeating “world Jewry”; and creating a German empire to the east in the Slav lands

taken from Germany in 1919. In the political maneuvers and campaigns from 1929 to 1935 that brought him to absolute power in Germany, he showed a ruthless instinct for his opponents’ weaknesses, alternating savage rhetoric and physical intimidation with gestures of moderation. Inherently given to fits of rage, he learned to manipulate this side of

his personality for effect, raging one moment, soothing the next. Those who thought they could control him—the military, politicians, businessmen—underestimated his power, to which they all eventually submitted.

Once in control, Hitler took little interest in the day-to-day business of government. While his subordinates worked to fulfill what they guessed to be “the Führer’s will,” the Führer himself dabbled in grandiose architectural projects, such as the huge Königsplatz in Munich, or enjoyed the Alpine views at his Berchtesgaden retreat. Hitler was a teetotal vegetarian obsessed with cleanliness—he had no taste for luxurious

Final days

On April 20, 1945, looking tired and haggard and facing imminent defeat, Hitler appeared in the Reichs Chancellery garden in Berlin with some of his officers. Ten days later, he committed suicide.

self-indulgence. His only intimate relationship was with Eva Braun, and little is known about it.

Having assured his dictatorial control of Germany, Hitler turned his obsession to the pursuit of power in foreign and military affairs. He used the same tactics to get his way on the world stage as he had in domestic politics—alternating threats of violence with offers of peace, and taking outrageous risks to achieve his aims.

War and downfall

In September 1939, Hitler invaded Poland and finally tipped Europe into war. The startling success of German arms fatally confirmed Hitler’s view of himself as an infallible leader. By the end of 1941 he had gone to war with both the Soviet Union and USA, and taken direct control of the German armed forces. When the tide of war turned against Germany, Hitler’s mental and physical state deteriorated and his grasp on reality weakened. Yet he never lost his savage desire for power. Obsessed with his own historical greatness, Hitler was quite prepared to see Germany destroyed to create a grandiose funeral pyre for his ego. Eventually, holed up in his Berlin bunker, Hitler realized he had been defeated. As the Soviet army advanced into the city, he committed suicide.



TIMELINE

- **April 20, 1889** Born in Braunau, Austria, the son of a customs official.
- **1907** Fails the entrance exam for the Viennese Academy of Fine Arts.
- **May 1913** Moves from Vienna to Munich to evade military service in Austria.
- **August 1914** Joins the German Army as a volunteer at the outbreak of World War I.
- **August 1918** Awarded the Iron Cross, First Class, after four years’ service as a dispatch runner on the Western Front.
- **1919** Comes in contact with the German Workers’ Party (DAP) in Munich.
- **July 1921** Becomes leader of renamed National Socialist German Workers’ Party (Nazi Party).
- **November 9, 1923** Attempts to overthrow the German government in Munich Putsch.
- **December 1924** Released from prison after serving nine months for treason.
- **March 1932** Belatedly takes German nationality and contests presidential elections, narrowly losing to Paul von Hindenburg.
- **January 30, 1933** Appointed chancellor through a backstairs deal with conservative German politicians and forms government.
- **March 23, 1933** Exploits crisis caused by a fire at the Reichstag (House of Representatives) on February 27; pushes through the Enabling Act to gain exceptional powers for four years.
- **June 30, 1934** Purges the SA (Stormtroopers), the Nazi Party’s paramilitary wing, in the “Night of the Long Knives”—more than 80 people are murdered.
- **August 19, 1934** Becomes dictator of Germany after the death of Paul von Hindenburg.
- **March 7, 1936** Sends German forces into the demilitarized Rhineland in defiance of the Versailles peace treaty.
- **March 12–13, 1938** Germany annexes Austria in the Anschluss.
- **September 29–30, 1938** Wins British and French backing for the German takeover of the Sudetenland area of Czechoslovakia at the Munich Conference.
- **September 1, 1939** Orders invasion of Poland, triggering World War II.
- **March 30, 1941** Addresses his generals about the planned invasion of the Soviet Union and calls for “a war of annihilation”; the invasion is launched on June 22.
- **December 11, 1941** Declares war on the United States after the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor.
- **December 19, 1941** Takes personal command of the German armed forces.
- **July 20, 1944** Survives an assassination attempt at his headquarters at Rastenburg.
- **April 30, 1945** Shoots himself in his bunker in Berlin as the city falls to the Soviet Red Army.



AUSTRIAN STAMP 1945